

BAKELITE

In 1907, Leo Baekeland—a Belgian-born chemist working in the US—made a plastic from chemicals found in coal tar. His plastic, which he called Bakelite, was different from earlier plastics because heat made it set hard, rather than melt.

Bakelite-made rotary dial telephone, 1940s



POLYSTYRENE

Although the history of polystyrene goes back to the 1830s, it was first developed for commercial use in the 1930s. It comes in two forms: hard, and a lightweight foam, called expanded polystyrene or styrofoam. The hard form is used for items such as yogurt cartons; the lightweight type makes good packaging, especially egg boxes (left).

PLASTIC BOTTLES

In 1947, plastic bottles were first used commercially. However, they remained uncommon until developments in plastics in the 1960s reduced costs. Soon after, plastic bottles became popular due to their light weight and the fact that, unlike glass, they don't break.



► PRACTICAL PLASTIC

Today's plastic bottles come in all shapes and sizes, and can carry anything from water to fizzy drinks.



WALLACE CAROTHERS

American chemist Wallace Carothers produced a plastic called nylon in 1934. This revolutionary new material could be woven into a fine cloth or twined to create rope as strong as steel cable. Thin and durable, nylon is used to create many items, from hosiery to guitar strings.



SQUEEZABLE KETCHUP BOTTLE

This handy bottle for ketchup was created by Stanley Mason, a prolific American inventor who also holds patents on such essentials of modern life as disposable diapers and dental-floss dispensers. In 1983, his bottle was first manufactured for home use by the food company Heinz.